ONTOLOGICAL ARGUMENT

THE ONTOLOGICAL ARGUMENT

- This is an *a priori* argument for the existence of God, it starts with a definition of God, and then unpacks the idea of God to prove that God exists.

- A priori arguments are argument that do not need recourse to experience of the external world, in order to prove a conclusion. They tend to start with an idea, or the definition of an idea.

THERE ARE TWO ASSUMPTIONS TO THE ARGUMENT

1. That which is greater has more being (existence) than they which is lesser.

2. A necessary entity has greater being than that which is contingent.

NECESSARY AND CONTINGENT BEINGS



A *necessary* being is being or a fact which it would be a contradiction to deny. For example the fact that 2+2=4



A *contingent* being or state of affairs is one which it is not a contradiction to deny. For example that there are 8 planets in the solar system.

ONTOLOGICAL ARGUMENTS

1. Anselm of Canterbury – 1033 -1106

2. Rene Descartes -

3. Norman Malcolm

ANSELM'S PROSLOGION

Anselm understood Theology to be '*faith seeking understanding*'. He wrote in his proslogion, that

'*you who grant understanding to faith…you are, as we believe you are, and that you are what we believe you to be*'. He defines God as '*that you are something than which nothing greater can be thought*'.

This means that Anselm's argument is theological and not strictly philosophical.

ANSELM'S ONTOLOGICAL ARGUMENT

1. God is something than which nothing greater can be thought.
2. Something than which nothing greater can be thought exists in the understanding.
3. Something than which nothing greater can be thought is something which 'can be thought to exist in reality as well, which is greater'.
4. Something than which nothing greater must therefore be thought exists in reality.
5. God exists in reality.

COMMENTARY (1)

(2) means that because anyone can understand the idea of something which nothing greater can be thought, then that idea must exist in the understanding.

'The analogy here is that of the painter and his work. Before the painting exists in reality, it exists in his understanding as a merely possible painting; once the painter has completed the work, it exists both in the understanding and in reality as well'.

COMMENTARY (2)

- (3) claims that something that exists in the understanding alone can also be thought to exist in reality, and that second thought, something which we think to exist in reality as well as in the understanding is a greater thought. So this is the greatest possible idea.

- This leads to (4) Something than which nothing greater must therefore be thought exists in reality.

- Given that this is the definition of God, we can infer that God exists in reality.

ANSELM THEN MAKES THE FOLLOWING INFERENCE

Something that exists necessarily is greater than something which exists contingently.

Conclusion - God exists necessarily.

There are two objections to Anselm's argument:

(1) That we cannot think about the greatest possible being.

(2) That even if we could it would not prove the existence of God.

GAUNILO AND THE PERFECT ISLAND ARGUMENT

He asks us to consider an imaginary island…'*This island (so the story goes) is more plentifully endowed than all the islands of the Blessed, with an indescribable abundance of all sorts of riches and delights. And because it has neither owner nor inhabitants, it is everywhere superior in its abundant riches to all the other lands that human beings inhabit. Suppose someone tells me all this. The story is easily told, and involves no difficulty, and so I understand it, but if this person went on to draw the conclusion, and say, 'you cannot any longer doubt that this island, more excellent than all the other on earth, truly exists somewhere in reality, this island must also exist in reality, for if it is not, any land that exists in reality would be greater than it. And so this more excellent thing which you jave understood would not in fact be more excellent'. – If he should try to convince me by this argument that I should no longer doubt whether the island truly exists, either I should think that he is joking, or I would not know who to think more foolish:*'

The is a reductio ad absurdum – a reduction to absurdity

ANSELM'S RESPONSE TO GAUNILO

(1) We can think of the greatest possible being. We can think about things that exist, and things that do not exist, the only thing we cannot think about are impossible ideas, like a 'square, triangle'. And the idea of 'That which nothing greater can be conceived' is a coherent idea, it is not impossible to think. We can do this by working up from lower things.

(2) What can happen with ideas, is that I can suppose myself to be thinking about something which I am not actually thinking about. For example, I might suppose myself to be thinking about the number 1 when I am actually thinking about the number 3. In other words, my ideas an 'misfire'.

(3) This is the mistake of someone who thinks they are contemplating God, when they are not.

(4) This means that when you really are thinking about God, you realize that he must exist.

ANSELM'S DISTINCTION

This is a key part of Anselm's argument.

1. We can 'say something' without at the same time 'actually thinking it'. And so, it can look like we have thought it. (Empty intuition)

2. *We can say something and be thinking of it*, and this is an example of genuine thought. (Categorical intuition)

ANSELM'S SECOND RESPONSE

1. It is an 'intrinsic property' of the idea of God (a being greater than which nothing can be conceived) that it exists. In other words, the idea of existence is an essential part of the idea of God, just as lines are an essential part of the existence of a triangle. In other words, you cannot think a triangle without thinking of lines.

2. The idea of an island, is the idea of a body of land surrounded by water, it does not have attached to it, the idea of a real island anywhere in the world.

DESCARTES ONTOLOGICAL ARGUMENT

Descartes starts with a very specific definition of God.

'The idea of God (that is of a supremely perfect being) is certainly one that I find within me…; and I understand from this idea that it belongs to God's nature *that he always exists*'.

DESCARTES ARGUMENT

1. I have the idea of God.
2. The idea of God is the idea of a supremacy perfect being.
3. A supremely perfect being does not lack any perfection.
4. Existence is a perfection.
5. Therefore, God exists.

MEDITATION V

- Like Anselm Descartes claimed that if we were actually thinking of God, and not just saying the word God then we must think him as existing.

- *'Now admittedly it is not necessary that I should light upon any thought of God; but whenever I do choose to think of the first and supreme being, and bring forth the idea of God from the treasure house of my mind as it were, it is necessary that I attribute perfections to him, even if I do not at that time enumerate them or attend to them individually. And this necessity plainly guarantees that, when I later realize that existence is a perfection, I am correct in inferring that the first supreme being exists.'*

IT IS MORE PERFECT TO EXIST NECESSARILY THAN CONTINGENTLY

- It is more perfect to exist necessarily than contingently so God must exist necessarily.
- Problem: If God exists necessarily, how is it possible to doubt his existence?
- Example. What is the sum of 223798+1232131=? The answer to this question is a necessary truth but not immediately obvious.

OBJECTIONS

- 1. Kant claimed that existence was not a perfection.
- 2. Hume claimed that the idea of a necessary being was illogical. The only things that are necessary are relations of ideas.
- 3. Hume: Even if there is a perfect being, it will probably not be the God of classical theism. (Hume).

QUESTIONS

MALCOLM'S ONTOLOGICAL ARGUMENT